Festivals

Odisha is a land of festivals. While the Rath Yatra of Puri is justly renowned all over the world and is an intricate part of the cultural fabric of Odisha, there are several tourist festivals which are also big draws.

NATIONAL CHILIKA BIRD FESTIVAL

Timed to coincide with the arrival of lakhs of winged visitors of around 200 species at Mangalajodi during the balmy Odisha winters, the National Chilika Bird Festival is a birder's dream come true. Photographers can have a field day here, since the birds are seen at eye level and at close proximity. Mangalajodi, situated in the north-eastern part of Chilika, the largest brackish water lake of Asia, is the 'Birds Paradise of Asia' and a shining beacon in the conservation story of India. It shows how conservation can generate livelihood and deal with the menace of poaching.

A major highlight of the festival is a visit to the Nalabana Bird Sanctuary, a beautiful island in the heart of Lake Chilika. The National Chilika Bird Festival is the only time when Nalabana is opened for nature lovers to witness this beautiful bird haven. Activities at the Bird Festival include birdwatching, sanctuary visit, nature walks, boating, technical sessions and photography.

KONARK FESTIVAL

One of India's biggest tourism festivals, The 33-year-old Konark Festival celebrates dance, music and art in a venue where every stone has a story to tell. The enthralling Konark Festival is held every year from 1-5 December, at the Open-Air Auditorium, Konark, with the backdrop of the mammoth Sun Temple, and provides a platform for classical dancers in India and abroad as well as to showcase their talents. It also a great platform for budding artists.

Conceived as a festival to celebrate the nine Classical Dances of India—including Odissi, which originated in the temples of Odisha—the objective of the Konark Festival is to promote Konark, as well as Odisha as a tourist destination. The Konark Festival showcases the best of the traditional and classical dance forms of India, besides offering interesting insights into the rich cultural and dance heritage of the country like no other festival. A wonderful Crafts Mela is held at Urban Haat, Konark at the time of the Konark Festival which adds to the magic of the Festival.

INTERNATIONAL SAND ART FESTIVAL

The International Sand Art Festival, in its 12th edition now, is held on Chandrabhaga Beach at the same time as the Konark Festival, a few kilometres from Konark. The Sand Festival celebrates sand sculptures produced by talented sand artists from across India as well as from many other countries like Mexico, Spain, Singapore, France, Norway, Germany, Netherland & USA. The golden Chandrabhaga Beach becomes a artist's playground during the Festival. Apart from sand sculptures, you can also see stone, bronze and wood sculptures here. Every year, the Festival's theme centres around major global issues.